

Supporting Emeritus Scientists in Research

V. Norris¹, G.J. White² & L. Trilling³

¹Laboratoire de Microbiologie CBSA, Université de Rouen, 27000 Évreux, France

²Department of Physics and Astronomy, The Open University, MK7 6AA, UK

³Laboratoire TIMC, Université Grenoble Alpes, 38700 La Tronche, France

Emeritus professors make substantial contributions to science through continuing research, refereeing manuscripts, mentoring early-career colleagues, and advising institutions. They do this often at negligible cost to their institutions. Yet support varies widely internationally, from active emeritus programmes at ETH Zürich, Leiden and in the UK to largely honorary status with minimal infrastructure in France, Italy, and Spain.

The evidence does not support assumptions of inevitable decline at retirement age. Nearly 40 percent of U.S.-trained doctoral scientists aged 71 to 75 remain actively employed. While individual productivity varies, the question is whether systems enable those wishing to contribute to do so.

The concern about competition with early-career scientists is valid, but reflects a zero-sum view of research funding. Emeriti typically require different support since they bring collaborative funding, contribute to ongoing projects, and take on reviewing and administrative work that would otherwise burden mid-career colleagues.

We propose four practical steps. First, institutions should provide basic infrastructure such as institutional affiliation, email, library access and, where feasible, workspace. Second, international mobility should be encouraged through retired scientist exchange programmes between countries. Third, funding bodies should adopt age-blind grant eligibility assessed on merit alone. Fourth, modest emeritus-specific funding should support collaborative projects that pair senior expertise with junior innovation.

The financial case is straightforward. Supporting 1,000 emeritus professors with 10,000 euros each would cost 10 million euros annually, which is negligible compared to Horizon Europe's 93.5 billion euro budget. More importantly, science is conducted by people. The knowledge, judgment and connections accumulated over long careers do not expire when employment ends. A research system that discards these resources due to age is not being efficient. It is being wasteful.

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